

# Allied Tanks: 1939-40

After the German invasion of Poland on September 1, 1939, the Polish forces fought bravely, but were overwhelmed by the Germans and their Soviet allies. In May 1940, the French and British forces, facing the German invasion of Western Europe, had more tanks than their opponents, and many were superior on paper. However, they were spread thinly rather than concentrated into large units, and the shock of the German invasion, combined with poor tactics, had a strong psychological impact on Allied commanders. As a result, most of the Allied tanks that fought in 1940 were captured or abandoned.

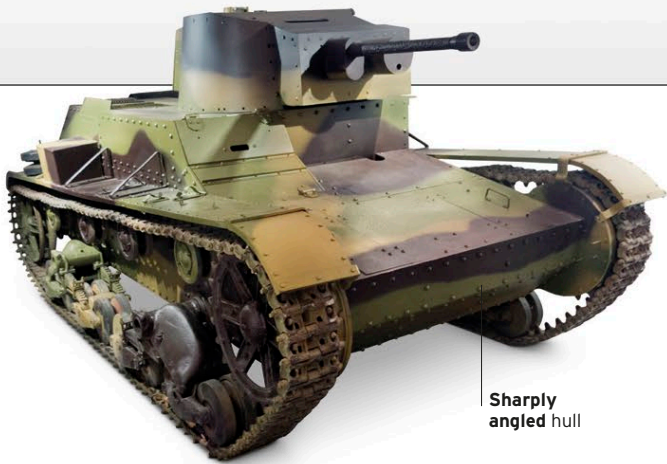


Rounded hull areas deflect projectiles

Armor covers road wheels

|               |                            |
|---------------|----------------------------|
| △             | <b>SOMUA S35</b>           |
| Date          | 1935                       |
| Country       | France                     |
| Weight        | 21.5 tons (19.5 tonnes)    |
| Engine        | Somua V-8 gasoline, 190 hp |
| Main armament | 47 mm SA 35 gun            |

The S35 was made of cast steel, which provided much better armor protection than riveted panels. It had a crew of three, but only a one-man turret, so the commander had to load, aim, and fire the gun, as well as command the tank.



Sharply angled hull

|               |                             |
|---------------|-----------------------------|
| △             | <b>7TP</b>                  |
| Date          | 1937                        |
| Country       | Poland                      |
| Weight        | 10.5 tons (9.6 tonnes)      |
| Engine        | Saurer VLDBb diesel, 110 hp |
| Main armament | 37 mm Bofors wz.37 L/45 gun |

The 7TP was a Polish development of the Vickers Mark E. A small number of 7TPs had twin machine gun turrets, but most of the approximately 150 tanks built had a single turret armed with a 37 mm gun. The 7TPs were superior to most German tanks in 1939, but they were too few to affect the outcome of the invasion of Poland.

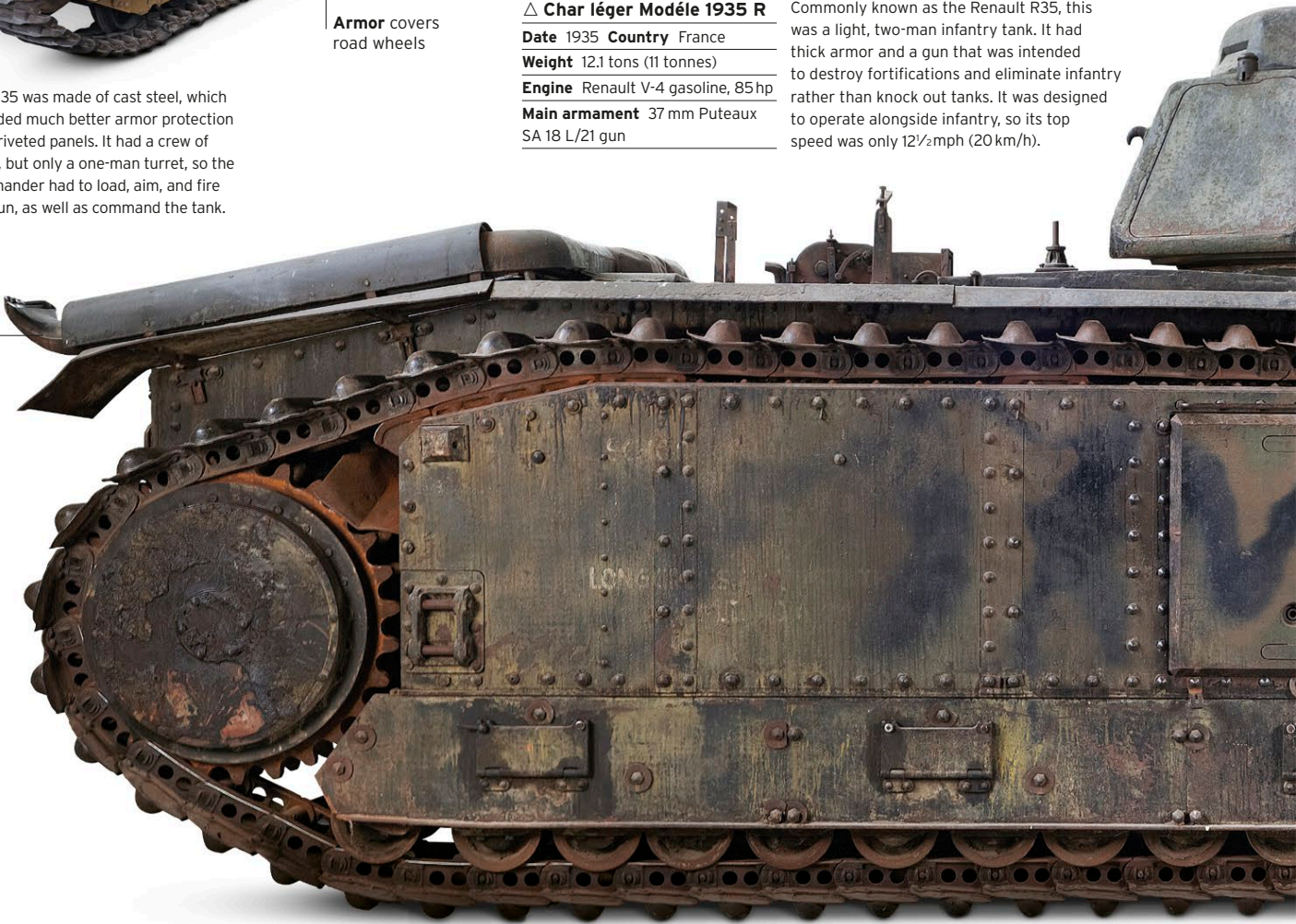


Hexagonal one-man turret

Vision port

|               |                                 |
|---------------|---------------------------------|
| △             | <b>Char léger Modèle 1935 R</b> |
| Date          | 1935                            |
| Country       | France                          |
| Weight        | 12.1 tons (11 tonnes)           |
| Engine        | Renault V-4 gasoline, 85 hp     |
| Main armament | 37 mm Puteaux SA 18 L/21 gun    |

Commonly known as the Renault R35, this was a light, two-man infantry tank. It had thick armor and a gun that was intended to destroy fortifications and eliminate infantry rather than knock out tanks. It was designed to operate alongside infantry, so its top speed was only 12½mph (20 km/h).



Engine exhaust pipe

|               |                                                              |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| ▷             | <b>Char B1 bis</b>                                           |
| Date          | 1936                                                         |
| Country       | France                                                       |
| Weight        | 34.7 tons (31.5 tonnes)                                      |
| Engine        | Renault V12 gasoline, 307 hp                                 |
| Main armament | 1 x 75mm ABS 1929 SA 35 L/17.1 howitzer, 1 x 47 mm SA 35 gun |

The most powerful French tank in 1940, the B1 bis was armed with a 75 mm infantry support gun in the hull and a 47 mm antitank gun in the usual one-man turret. It was very heavily armored, but suffered from slow speed and limited range. This was a result of being in development since the 1920s; by the time it was ready, it had already been overtaken by other models.